

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Natural Revelation

When God speaks directly to people, we call it *special revelation*. God also speaks to everyone indirectly through *natural revelation* (also known as *general revelation* because it is given to all). This happens through the natural world God created. For example, [Psalm 19](#) says that knowledge of God in creation is available to everyone everywhere (see [Psalm 19:1-4](#)).

Sadly, not everyone responds positively to God. Paul explains in [Romans 1-3](#) that because of Adam's sin, all people turn away from the knowledge of God found in creation. Without God's grace, natural revelation only condemns people. As Paul says in [1:20](#), people "are without excuse."

God can use creation to help people realize he is the one true God. When God's grace supports and empowers this natural revelation, the world's beauty and complexity can inspire a search for the Creator. Paul appealed to natural revelation when he was in Athens as a way to introduce the good news about Jesus ([Acts 17:16-31](#)). God's revelation in the natural world and in human nature can encourage people to search for him. And then, through the special revelation God has ultimately given in his Son, Jesus Christ, people can truly know him and experience salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 19:1-4](#); [Acts 14:15-17](#); [Acts 17:24-29](#); [Romans 1:19-21](#)

Nehemiah's Confidence in God

God gave the prophet Nehemiah favor with a powerful Persian king. The king agreed to all of Nehemiah's requests ([Nehemiah 1:11](#); [2:8](#), [18](#)). Nehemiah then confidently shared his bold plan to rebuild Jerusalem's walls. The people of Jerusalem trusted God would help them succeed and protect them from enemies ([2:18](#); [4:4-5](#), [9](#)).

They continued their work despite opposition. They knew God fights for his people and disrupts evil plans ([4:14-15](#), [20](#)). When they completed the walls, Nehemiah acknowledged that the challenging project succeeded only with God's help ([6:16](#)).

The book of Nehemiah shows that God is all-powerful and can achieve his plans in both personal lives and nations. The prayer in [Nehemiah 9](#) praises God for his powerful acts. God created the heavens and earth, called Abram from Ur, and gave the land to Israel ([9:6](#); [7-8](#), [22-25](#)).

God demonstrated his power over people and creation to show care for his people in three main ways ([9:9-15](#)):

1. The miraculous signs in Egypt.
2. The parting of the Red Sea.
3. The provision of guidance, food, and water in the wilderness.

The Lord sent the Israelites into exile after many generations of sin ([Nehemiah 9:32-37](#)). Now, he was fulfilling his promise to restore them ([1:8-9](#)). Nehemiah prayed and led with confidence because he knew everything was part of God's plan.

This same trust in God led Abram to leave Ur and go to an unknown land ([Genesis 12:1-3](#); [Hebrews 11:8-10](#)). It caused Rahab to trust God ([Joshua 2:9-14](#); [Hebrews 11:31](#)). It prompted King Hezekiah to resist the king of Assyria, Sennacherib ([2 Kings 18:1-19:37](#)). Confidence comes when people trust God will keep his promises and complete the work he started in their lives ([Philippians 1:6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1-4](#); [Joshua 1:10-18](#); [2:9-14](#); [2 Kings 18:1-19:37](#); [Nehemiah 1:8-9](#), [11](#); [2:8](#), [18](#), [20](#); [4:4-5](#), [9](#), [14-15](#), [20](#); [6:16](#); [9:6-31](#); [Psalms 4:5](#); [9:10](#); [37:3](#); [40:3](#); [44:6-7](#); [56:3-12](#); [112:1-9](#); [Proverbs 3:5-12](#); [16:20](#); [28:1](#), [25](#); [Isaiah 26:3](#); [Hebrews 11:8-10](#), [31](#); [1 John 4:17](#)